

>> wake up the stretch

Your stretch journey starts with a sequence that creates suppleness and wakes up your stretch. No matter what level you're at, as you stretch your whole body, you'll find the fluid motion of this sequence as slinky as a long cat yawn. Try to imagine that you're "joining the dots" as you weave your way through each and every movement.

Stretching is a skill that everyone can master. This sequence emphasizes the various techniques you'll need and the sensory elements of stretch that together will help to make your stretch possible. Being able to identify muscle tone is a crucial first step. Next, learning to stabilize one part of the body while another moves away from the stabilizing part is key to the effectiveness of a lengthening stretch. Breathing into tight body areas such as the back of the rib cage demands discipline and focus. Loosening and circling motions help to oil the joints and loosen restrictive connective tissue, thus prompting muscles to expand and contract. Re-coordination exercises (see p.12) make new ranges of motion a possibility for everyone.

The exercises

Feel as much of your body as you can in the Hand pull. Memorize this muscular feeling and strive to carry that feeling into the rest of the sequence. Make the Elbow circles as sensory and luscious as if you were moving through a pool of honey. Direct the flow of your breath very specifically into any tight parts of the diaphragm. This exercise may feel difficult at first, but it can give you a very satisfying sense of relaxation.

The seated exercises may seem easy, but use the surface and structure of the chair to explore your orientation in space. Notice the relationship of your hip, rib, head, arm, and leg placements.

>> tips for wake up the stretch

- **Internalize your stretches** by giving as much detailed focus to your body sensations as possible.
- **Try to imagine** the infrastructure—the skeletal part that is moving—such as your arms moving against your upper torso.
- **Work to identify** which parts are anchoring and which parts are moving.
- **Strive to feel the entire path of the motion**, not just the end points.
- **Breathe in long, flowing, time-released breaths**, as suggested by the guide music; try not to hold your breath.

The physical boundary of the chair not only provides landmarks so you can judge how far a stretch is moving, it can also give you a sense of where your deep muscles are, which can help if you feel your movement is restricted. Sitting on a firm surface is also a sneaky way to feel some input up into your sit bones. This pressure gives a neurological stimulus to your "righting" reflex, which helps you to lengthen up against gravity.